CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

WELDER IN THE AI ERA

Ships, pipelines, skyscrapers, farm gates — everything metal holds together because someone fused it right. Your weld either passes inspection or it doesn't.

★ **TL;DR — Median around $75K — more in pipelines, plants and traveling work — with training in the 6–12 month band and skill certifications as the currency. The catch: your pay is your test results; welding is a certified-skill market disguised as a job.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

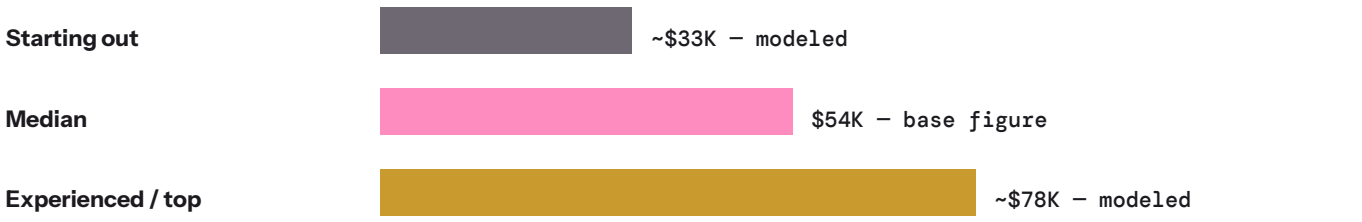
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$54K · TRAINING 6-12 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

- Works because: metal infrastructure constantly gets built, repaired and modified, and welds are legally inspected in the critical stuff.
- Bites because: shop production welding (the easiest to enter) pays least and automates first; the money lives in field, pipe and code work.
- AI angle: low for field and repair work. Robotic welders own repetitive factory seams, not shipyards, pipelines, plant shutdowns or broken farm equipment.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Welder is a ~$54K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A WELDER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Join metal with MIG, TIG, stick or flux-core processes — reading the puddle and controlling heat
- ✓ Fit up parts from drawings: cut, grind, clamp, tack, then weld to spec and sequence
- ✓ Inspect your own work (and inspectors inspect it after you): beads, penetration, porosity
- ✓ Work in shops, on construction sites, in plants — sometimes in confined, hot, awkward positions

Think: a surgeon whose stitches are load-bearing — one cold lap or crack can fail a structure, a pipeline, or an inspection that ends your contract.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Robotic cells weld identical parts by the thousand in factories. They still don't climb scaffolding, fit crooked repairs, or weld a cracked manifold in place in the rain.	Fit-up judgment, out-of-position skill, new-metal-meets-old-metal repairs, and passing X-ray/ultrasonic inspection under code. Certification tests are human gatekeeping that industry trusts precisely because they're hard to fake.

⚠ **Fumes, burns, arc flash and grinding dust are daily companions — ventilation and PPE are non-negotiable, and lungs keep score. Also: a welding certificate from school is not a job; employers test you on their plate, their process, their position.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Deep craft satisfaction — the bead either sings or it doesn't ✓ Specialties stack: pipe, structural, TIG, underwater — each a new pay band ✓ Traveling and shutdown work can be extremely lucrative in bursts	✗ Heat, sparks, cramped positions and heavy PPE ✗ Production-shop monotony at the entry end ✗ Your eyes and lungs need defending for a 40-year career

Good fit? You have steady hands, patience for repetition-with-precision, and you take pride in passing hard tests. Metal fascinates you.
Bad fit? You can't stand heat and confinement, or you expect the certificate alone to carry you. The weld test is always waiting.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — WELDING SCHOOL + CERTIFICATIONS	DOOR B — SHOP HAND / FITTER'S HELPER
A welding program (6–12 months) covering MIG, TIG, stick and flux-core, cutting, blueprint reading — plus AWS-style certification tests in the positions and processes employers want. School is where you buy hood time and test attempts in one package.	Get hired in a fab shop cutting, grinding and fitting; weld when the work allows and practice on breaks. Slower to certify, but you're paid from day one and real production teaches speed school can't.

Smart move: Certify in the hard positions and processes early — vertical and overhead pipe (6G) is the classic pay-jump test. General flat-position MIG is the most crowded, most automatable corner of the trade.

Where you land after: Welder → certified pipe/structural welder → welding inspector (CWI), foreman, or specialty contractor.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
CHOOSE PROCESSES	BUY HOOD	PASS CERTIFICATI	GET PRODUCTION	MOVE UP	INSPECTOR, FOREMAN,

STEP 1 — Choose processes by market

FREE · TODAY

- Check local postings: construction (stick/flux), fab shops (MIG), pipe and plant work (TIG/stick). Train for what's hiring near you.
- Tour a welding school and a fab shop before paying for either path.

STEP 2 — Buy hood time

$3,000-15,000 · 6-12 MO (SCHOOL)

- School route: full program with blueprint reading, metallurgy basics and all major processes.
- Shop route: helper job plus structured practice — coupons, positions, and a grinder in your hand daily.

STEP 3 — Pass certification tests

TEST FEES · PER PROCESS/POSITION

- AWS D1.1 structural and pipe certifications are the standard proof employers and inspectors accept.
- Treat every test like the job interview it is — because it literally becomes one.

STEP 4 — Get production reps

PAID · MONTHS

- Speed and consistency under real deadlines: fit-up, sequencing, minimal rework.
- Learn to read your own welds: undercut, porosity, cold lap — and fix causes, not symptoms.

STEP 5 — Move up the process ladder

YEAR 1+

- Add TIG and pipe if you started MIG; add field work if you started in a shop.
- Shutdown and turnaround seasons at plants pay premiums for certified, mobile welders.

STEP 6 — Inspector, foreman, or owner

YEAR 2+

- CWI (Certified Welding Inspector) converts your eye into a license-grade career without the hood.
- Ownership route: a rig, a truck and certifications — the classic pipeline/field welder setup.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: survey local welding postings by process; pick your first certification target.
- □ Days 1–30: enrolled in school or hired as a shop hand; daily hood time begins.
- □ Days 31–60: flat and horizontal down cold; start vertical practice — that's where tests get honest.
- □ Days 61–90: first certification test attempted or booked; a coupon portfolio photographed.
- □ Day 90: you're a welder in formation with test results — this trade's only résumé that matters.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ THE BEAD DOESN'T LIE. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.